

Ananya Panday, at 25, has officially entered the 'adulting' club. Or so she'd like to believe. She's got her own pad, albeit one in the same building as her folks—actor Chunky Panday and Bhavna Panday of *Fabulous Lives of Bollywood Wives* fame. "That's the furthest I will go away from them, at least at this point in my life," she says. Ananya is currently obsessing over shopping for crockery and hanging with her friends at her new abode. "My house is like a museum right now, because I don't allow people to eat, wear their shoes or touch anything," she says with a laugh. Cutting the umbilical cord, she admits, is proving harder than she imagined—she is still sleeping at the family home to be close to her dogs and her younger sister, who is visiting from New York. "At the start, it took some convincing for my parents when I said I'd move out. My mom was being dramatic and saying you are breaking up the family," she says. "Now they are like when are you moving out?"

The adulting Ananya is also showing up on screen. She earned the best reviews of her burgeoning career when she played Ahana, a needy 20-something seeking attention and validation from an ex on social media, in the Netflix film *Kho Gaye Hum Kahan*. It's the second time after *Gehraiyaan* (Amazon Prime) that Ananya has shown that, when placed in an urban chic milieu, she settles in like a fish in water. "I am very comfortable with it, as I have grown up in it; so, there's a lot I can bring to a character in terms of ideas and small nuances," she says. "It is close to my personality, but you can't just play yourself on screen all the time." In fact, they ended up being films she had to "work the hardest for". That meant spending time in workshops with the writer-director to develop the character.

With **KGHK** (above), Ananya has again shown that when placed in an urban chic milieu, she settles in like a fish in water

Ananya is aware that she won't always have such luxury of time and a wholesome experience. Not every film will be one where she feels like she belongs; not every film will give her the opportunity to immerse herself and not every on-set experience will be fun. "It's a bittersweet feeling," she says. Ananya admits that she's trying to "inculcate" the best practices from the two films into her upcoming slate because she sees the adulation that has come her way.

One came closer to home from Somen Mishra who heads creative development at Dharma and Dharmatic. "If you are surprised by Ananya Panday's natural turn in *Kho Gaye*... Let me say that Panday-ji will surprise you more in 2024," he wrote on X, likely referring to her upcoming titles, the Amazon Prime series *Call Me Bae* and an untitled Dharma film. Ananya turns coy when asked how she responds to declarations like that. "Oh god. I am always of the belief that don't set your expectations high because I'd rather surprise people than disappoint them," she says.

Ananya is a member of Hindi cinema's Gen Z brigade that includes Janhvi Kapoor, Suhana Khan, Khushi Kapoor and Agastya Nanda, and which will see new entrants in Shanaya Kapoor, Ibrahim Ali Khan, Aaman Devgan and Rasha Thadani in 2024. It's a crowded field, but Ananya says there's "room for everyone" to thrive. "The calibre of work is also great," she says. Ananya has more films up her sleeves compared to her besties, Shanaya, 24, and Suhana, 23, but she still has a cherubic appearance. "I have